Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 6 3 ♥ Q J ♦ A K 4 2 ♣ A 10 6 4	
♠ J 9 8 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ Q 10 9 6 ♣ K 9 5	N W E S	♠ Q 10 5 2 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ 8 7 ♣ J 8 7 2
	♠ A 7 4 ♥ K 10 9 8 3 ♦ J 5 3 ♣ Q 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

South's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2.

West plays the ♠J and you win with the ♠K.

East plays low.

West plays low too.

East plays low.

West holds up his ♥A again.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 5

Obviously you need to establish 4 ♥ winners and by driving out the ♥A you can manage that handily. The problem is that dummy has only one sure entry, (the ♠A), and the defenders may be good enough to hold up their ♥A twice.

To assure the contract you should win the first trick in your hand with the ♠K. Then play ♥Q, ♥J overtaking with dummy's ♥K so you can continue establishing the suit while you still have that ♠ entry.

None of the other suits were sitting well so overtaking the ♥ was the way to go.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ — ♥ 10 9 6 3 ♦ K Q J 9 4 ♣ Q 10 9 7	
♠ A J 6 4 ♥ 7 5 ♦ 6 3 ♣ A K 6 4 3		♠ K Q 9 8 7 5 2 ♥ A 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 5 2
	♠ 10 3 ♥ K Q J 8 4 ♦ 10 8 7 5 ♣ J 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♣	Pass	1♠	Pass
2♠	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♥[2]	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by East
Lead: ♥K

East is to play 6♠. South leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥5 and North the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and draw trumps with the ♠K and ♠Q.

South plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

One of the two red losers must be discarded on dummy's ♣ suit. So you pull trumps, taking two rounds, with ♠K and ♠Q. Then play two top ♣s and ruff a ♣. When South shows out on the third ♣, enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♣. Dummy's final ♣ is now established, so enter dummy with another trump and discard one of the red losers on the fifth ♣.

As long as the ♣s were no worse than 4-2 you can establish the suit.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A J 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ Q 6 4 3	
♠ K 6 4 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ K 10 8 6 2 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ A 8 ♥ Q 10 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 9 7
	♠ Q J 5 ♥ K 5 4 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
All Pass			

1NT by South
Lead: ♦6

South is to play 1NT. West leads the ♦6, taken by East with the ♦J. East next plays the ♦Q on which West plays the ♦2. East plays the ♦9 which you finally win.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

You only need one more winner and you have several possibilities. The ♥ finesse might work, or the ♣s might split 3-3. But you need to consider the defenders winners also. They have already scored 2 ♦ tricks and will get 2 more as soon as they gain the lead. (The spot cards told you that West has a 5-card ♦ suit.) Plus they have the 2 top ♠s which they can take whenever they like. So if your play sets up just one more trick for them you will go down.

No, you must establish ♠s, the suit where they have 2 winners anyway. So you play a ♠ which West wins. He takes his 2 ♦s but you are now home free. When you gain the lead again you will get your ♠ winner established and only lose 2 ♠s and 4 ♦s.

If you finessed the ♥ you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♥ and 2 ♠s.

If you had played 3 rounds of ♣s you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♣ and 2 ♠s.

Only by establishing ♠s can you make the contract.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 9 8 6 5 3 ♥ Q 9 3 2 ♦ K 4 ♣ 6 2	
♠ K J 7 ♥ A K 7 5 ♦ A 8 7 3 ♣ K Q	N W E S	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ 9 5 2 ♣ A 10 9 8 3
	♠ A 4 ♥ J 10 4 ♦ Q J 10 6 ♣ J 7 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠9

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♠9, taken by South with the ♠A. South next plays the ♠4.

You win with the ♠K and North plays low.

Everyone follows low.

North plays low.

South follows with the ♣5.

South wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You only need one more winner and if ♦s split 3-3 you can easily establish a trick in that suit. But what if ♦s split 4-2? If the ♣J falls you can get an extra ♣ trick. In fact, no matter how the ♣s are arranged you can establish your extra trick there.

First make sure that you win the second trick with the ♠K, keeping dummy's ♠Q for a later entry. Then play ♣K, and ♣Q overtaking with dummy's ♣A. Then play the ♣10, losing to the ♣J but establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♠Q as an entry.

As you see, you couldn't set up a ♦ trick so the ♣ overtake was necessary to make the contract.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 7 6 3 ♥ A K 5 2 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ A 7 5	
♠ K J 9 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 9 2	N W E S	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ K Q J 10
	♠ A 8 5 2 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K 7 4 ♣ 8 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	2NT
All Pass			

2NT by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 2NT. East leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and West the ♣2.

East plays low.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 7

You need to find another winner and the chances are not good. If either black suit splits 3-3 you can establish dummy's fourth card in that suit. But with East's opening lead of the ♣K it is unlikely that ♣s will split. So your only slim hope is that the ♠s split 3-3 and dummy's fourth ♠ will be a winner.

Win the first trick and play a ♠ to the ♠A. Then play another ♠. The defense will win and probably take some ♣ tricks . When they have finished and play a red card, you win it and play a third round of ♠s. If both defenders follow to all three ♠s then dummy's ♠8 is now a winner.

This time you were lucky and the ♠s split evenly. Next time they probably won't and you'll go down.